WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

SYRIA

Middle East

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Damascus	Capital and seat of government; a $4 billion-plus airport concession led by UCC Holding aims to lift capacity from about 500,000 to 6 million passengers by end-2026, and the Damascus Free Zone is fully occupied	Aviation, real estate, services, financial services
Tartus	Mediterranean port where DP World has committed $800 million to upgrade infrastructure under an agreement with the General Authority for Land and Sea Ports	Port logistics, transshipment, free-zone trade
Latakia	Principal container port, operated by CMA CGM under a 30-year contract signed in May 2025, with a fully occupied free zone	Shipping, logistics, light manufacturing
Baniyas	Mediterranean oil terminal and terminus of the 800 km Kirkuk–Baniyas pipeline, which Iraq and Syria agreed in June 2026 to rehabilitate	Oil transit, refining, energy services
Aleppo	Historic industrial and trading capital close to Türkiye; its free zone is being rehabilitated and Saudi-backed contracts to develop Aleppo International Airport have been reported	Textiles, manufacturing, trade, aviation
North-east (Deir ez-Zor, Raqqa, Hasakah)	Main oil, gas and grain region; major fields and border crossings passed to state control under the January 2026 government–SDF agreement	Oil and gas, agriculture, power generation
Central and north-west (Hama, Homs, Idlib)	Host sites for new power plants under the UCC-led partnership (including Mhardeh and Zayzoun), with an Idlib free zone being activated in phases to 2028	Power generation, agro-processing, industrial zones

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Syrian Investment Authority licensing under Investment Law 114 of 2025 (amending Law No. 18 of 2021): up to 100% foreign ownership, repatriation of profits and capital, compensation guarantees, full tax exemption for agricultural and medical projects and up to 80% tax relief for exporters

- Sanctions-clearance route: the US Syria sanctions programme was revoked by executive order on 30 June 2025, the Caesar Act was repealed in December 2025 and the State Sponsor of Terrorism designation was rescinded on 24 August 2026, but individual SDN designations and some export-licence requirements remain
- EU and UK regimes: the EU lifted most economic sanctions in May 2025 and has renewed listings linked to the former Assad regime until 1 June 2027; the UK revoked its gold and luxury-goods bans in April 2026 while retaining designations and some security-related restrictions
- Free zones run by the General Establishment for Free Zones (Damascus, Latakia, Aleppo, Tartus, with Idlib being developed), where 800 investor contracts have been signed and around 90% of ready-built facilities are occupied
- Concession and partnership route for infrastructure: ports via the General Authority for Land and Sea Ports, airports via the civil aviation authority and power plants via the Ministry of Energy, as used by DP World, CMA CGM and the UCC-led consortium
- Currency and banking: the Central Bank of Syria has introduced a new currency and restored SWIFT transfers; the banking system is being rebuilt and Syria remains on the FATF grey list, so payment channels need enhanced due diligence
- Donor-financed procurement: $493 million of World Bank IDA grants across electricity, water, health, public finance and financial-sector modernisation, alongside Gulf-backed packages such as the $6.4 billion Saudi–Syrian forum agreements

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Syria in October 2026 is one of the region's clearest reconstruction stories, and its legal position has changed fundamentally. The US revoked its Syria sanctions programme in June 2025, Congress repealed the Caesar Act in December 2025, and the State Sponsor of Terrorism designation was rescinded on 24 August 2026; the EU and UK have lifted most economic measures, and the UN removed President Ahmed al-Sharaa from its sanctions list in November 2025. The economy began to recover in 2025, when about 1.5 million refugees returned and the budget closed with a small surplus, and IMF staff now expect double-digit growth in 2026. Investor interest is substantial: some $25 billion of memorandums had been signed by October 2025, including a $14 billion infrastructure package, a $7 billion power partnership and $6.4 billion of Saudi agreements, while Investment Law 114 offers full foreign ownership and repatriation guarantees and the World Bank has returned with $493 million in grants.

Syria's central challenge is scale: the World Bank estimates reconstruction needs at $216 billion, and nominal GDP fell from $67.5 billion in 2011 to about $21.4 billion in 2024. Generation of about 3,000 MW meets less than a third of estimated demand of 10,000 MW, and the IMF describes rebuilding the banking system as of critical importance. These gaps are being addressed in a structured way: daily power supply rose from about 3 to 13 hours in 2025, new plants and port concessions are under way, the Central Bank has completed a currency changeover, and an IMF technical assistance programme covers new central bank and banking laws, tax reform and removal from the FATF grey list. Higher import prices linked to the regional conflict have lifted inflation in 2026, but the same conflict has raised Syria's value as an overland route to the Mediterranean, reflected in the plan to revive the Kirkuk–Baniyas pipeline. For investors with sound compliance, the size of the gap is the opportunity.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Remaining US designations and export controls	Country-wide US sanctions have ended, but persons linked to Assad, human-rights abuses, Captagon trafficking, proliferation, ISIS, al-Qa'ida and Iran remain designated, and some EAR licence requirements still apply	Screen every counterparty and its owners against the SDN list, take US sanctions and export-control counsel, and track the US administration's 180-day reviews of Syria's progress
Differing EU, UK and UN regimes	EU listings linked to the former Assad regime run to 1 June 2027 and the UK retains designations and an interception-services ban; UN listings now focus on ISIS and al-Qa'ida-linked individuals	Confirm the position separately in each jurisdiction involved; most commercial sectors are now open under all three regimes
Banking system and FATF grey list	Correspondent banking is still thin and Syria remains under FATF increased	Use established regional banks, document funds flows thoroughly and follow the

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	monitoring, although SWIFT transfers have resumed	IMF-supported banking and AML/CFT reforms now under way
Security and territorial consolidation	The January 2026 agreement returned the north-east to state authority, but ISIS remnants and Israeli military activity in the south persist	Prioritise Damascus, the coast and secured industrial zones, use professional security advice and phase investment as stabilisation advances
Power and infrastructure deficit	Generation of about 3,000 MW against estimated demand of 10,000 MW constrains industry	Build in self-generation or solar, and treat power, grid and water as investment opportunities in their own right
Inflation and new currency	Inflation slowed to low double digits in 2025 but rose in 2026 on import prices and wage increases; a new currency has been introduced	Price contracts in hard currency where permitted, hedge local costs and model the IMF's expected easing of inflation in 2027
Discretionary licensing and asset title	Licences are granted centrally, and some assets may be linked to former regime figures	Carry out thorough ownership and title due diligence, document approvals and use the investment arbitration centre launched in April 2026

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Syria's risk profile has improved markedly since 2025, and for most commercial sectors the main sanctions barriers have now been removed. US investors no longer face a country-wide embargo: the Syria sanctions programme, the Caesar Act and the State Sponsor of Terrorism designation have all ended, and the EU, UK and UN have eased or removed their principal measures. The compliance obligations that remain are targeted, not general. Individuals and entities linked to the former Assad regime, human-rights abuses, Captagon trafficking, proliferation, ISIS, al-Qa'ida and Iran remain designated, some US export-licence requirements still apply pending new Commerce rules, and Washington will review Syria's progress every 180 days over four years, with power to sanction individuals. Every transaction should therefore be screened by sanctions counsel in each relevant jurisdiction. Banking connectivity, power supply and security in some areas also need careful planning. With these safeguards in place, Syria offers early-mover access to one of the world's largest reconstruction programmes.

MARKET ACCESS

Syria's Mediterranean ports at Latakia, Tartus and Baniyas, now operated or being upgraded by CMA CGM and DP World, make it a natural gateway between the Mediterranean, Iraq, Jordan and the Gulf. The country is a member of the Greater Arab Free Trade Area and has been engaged in WTO accession since members agreed in 2010 to open talks. Trade with Türkiye is growing fast: Turkish exports to Syria rose about 70% to $2.57 billion in 2025, led by grain and food products. The 2026 regional conflict, which has disrupted tanker traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, has added interest in overland and pipeline routes, and Iraq and Syria agreed in June 2026 to rehabilitate the Kirkuk–Baniyas oil pipeline. With most Western sanctions lifted, re-established SWIFT links and Gulf and Turkish capital flowing in, Syria's market access is broadening quickly.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (Ahmed al-Sharaa)	Sets reconstruction and economic policy, and oversees the Supreme Council for Economic Development and the Syrian Investment Authority	Primary reference point for strategic direction and large-scale projects
Syrian Investment Authority (Chairman Talal al-Hilali)	Licenses projects and administers incentives under Investment Law 114 of 2025	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentive guidance
Central Bank of Syria (Governor Mohammed Safwat Raslan)	Manages the new currency, banking-sector rehabilitation and reconnection to international payment systems	Key counterpart on banking, payments and repatriation matters

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Ministry of Finance (Mohammed Barnieh)	Leads tax reform, the budget and the World Bank grant programme	Relevant for fiscal incentives and donor-financed procurement
Ministry of Energy	Oversees power generation, oil and gas, including the UCC-led power partnership and the north-east fields	Essential partner for energy and utilities investment
General Authority for Land and Sea Ports	Awards and supervises port concessions, including Tartus (DP World) and Latakia (CMA CGM)	Counterpart for port, logistics and transit investment
General Establishment for Free Zones	Operates Syria's free zones, with 800 investor contracts signed	Entry route for trading, warehousing and light manufacturing
Ministry of Foreign Affairs (Asaad al-Shibani)	Leads sanctions diplomacy and regional agreements such as the Kirkuk–Baniyas pipeline accord	Relevant for understanding Syria's international normalisation path

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Saudi–Syrian Investment Forum, held in Damascus in July 2025, produced 47 agreements, and Saudi, Qatari, Emirati and Turkish companies are now the most active foreign investors, which makes them useful partners and sources of practical intelligence. The Syrian Investment Authority promotes opportunities at international events such as the World Governments Summit, and the Damascus and Aleppo chambers of commerce and industry are the main channels to local business. The World Bank, with $493 million in IDA grants, and the IMF, through its technical assistance programme, are engaged again, creating procurement and advisory openings. The Syrian diaspora in Europe, the Gulf and Türkiye is an important source of partners and capital.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Syria best suits investors with a reconstruction focus, a tolerance for early-stage markets and strong compliance capability. Gulf and Turkish developers, contractors and infrastructure investors are leading on ports, airports, power and real estate. Logistics and transit investors can benefit from the Mediterranean ports and the pipeline revival. Agriculture, agri-food and healthcare investors benefit from full tax exemptions under the investment law, and export-oriented manufacturers from up to 80% tax relief. Engineering, equipment and advisory firms can take part in World Bank-funded programmes. Western investors in most sectors can now enter lawfully, provided they carry out rigorous counterparty screening and stay alert to residual designations and export-licence requirements.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Commission a multi-jurisdiction sanctions and export-control review
Confirm the US, EU, UK and UN position for the specific sector, goods and counterparties before any commitment, and screen beneficial owners against all current lists.

STEP 2: Engage the Syrian Investment Authority on licensing and incentives
Clarify eligibility under Investment Law 114, including ownership, repatriation and tax terms, and document approvals in full.

STEP 3: Plan banking and payment channels early
Identify compliant correspondent routes through established regional banks, given FATF grey-list status and the ongoing rebuilding of the banking system.

STEP 4: Target concession, free-zone and donor-financed opportunities
Follow port, power, airport and free-zone tenders and World Bank-funded procurement, which offer structured and well-documented entry points.

STEP 5: Phase entry with security and title due diligence
Start in Damascus, the coastal ports or free zones, take professional security advice and verify asset title and ownership history before expanding inland.